Aesthetics - Structural Correspondence with the Five-Stage Model

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Aesthetics

Structural correspondence survey with the five-stage model (Ba, Nami, En, Uzu, Taba)

Survey Overview

- **Scope**: 10 major theories in aesthetics
- **Research question**: Do theories in aesthetics structurally correspond to the five-stage model?
- **Results**: Strong correspondence 9, Partial correspondence 1

Overview of the Five-Stage Model

Stage	Definition
Ba (Field)	An undifferentiated state. Initial conditions where neither direction nor structure has yet been determined
Nami (Wave)	A stage of exploration where multiple directions diverge and compete
En (Edge)	A state of tension where opposing elements coexist without converging to either side. A place where elements meet at boundaries, influence each other, and relationships emerge
Uzu (Vortex)	A stage where new coherence (order) spontaneously arises from within tension
Taba (Bundle)	A stage where form is established and stabilizes as a reusable structure

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Overall Structural Correspondence

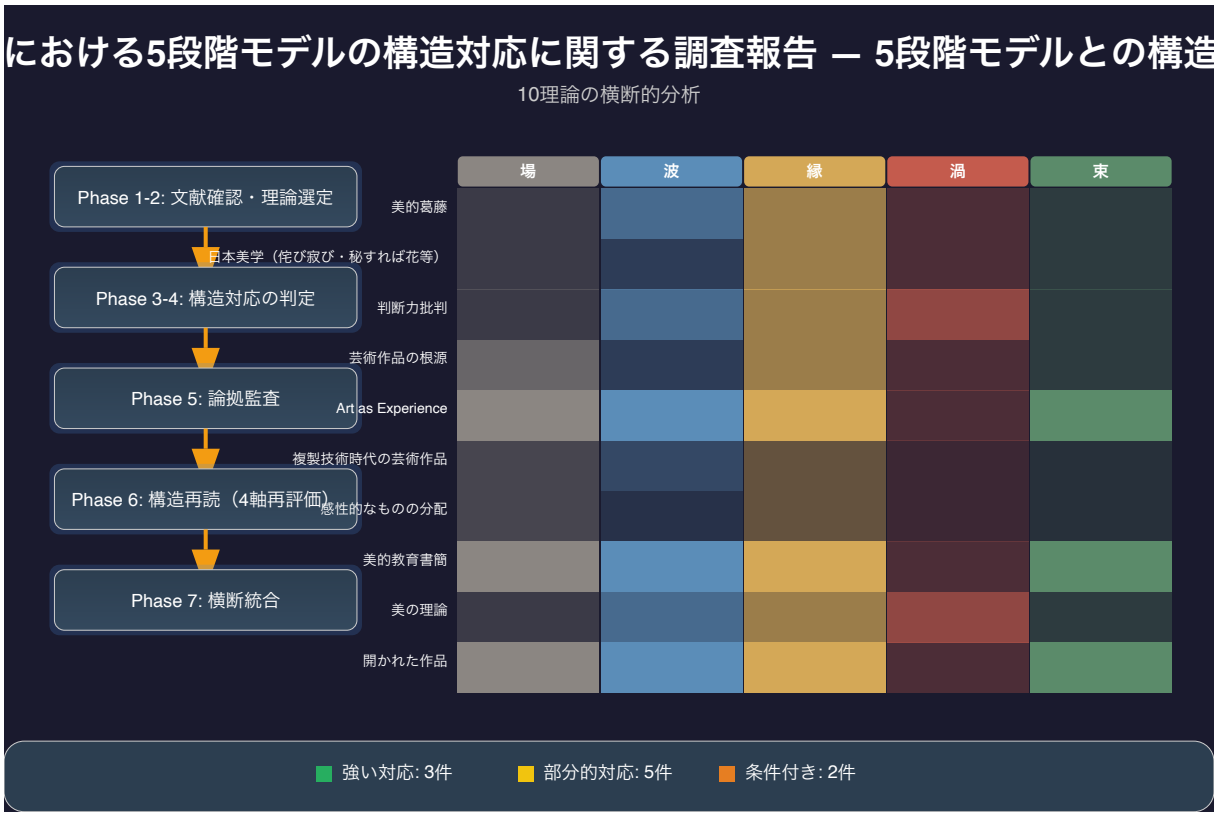

Figure 1: Domain — Research Overview Infographic

#	Theory/Concept	Proponent	Corresponding Stages	Assessment
1	Aesthetic conflict	Meltzer (1988)	All 5 stages	Strong correspondence
2	Japanese aesthetics and the structure of holding	Zeami, Motoori Norinaga, Hisamatsu Shin'ichi, and others	All 5 stages (particularly strong in En)	Strong correspondence
3	Critique of Judgment	Kant (1790)	All 5 stages	Partial correspondence
4	The Origin of the Work of Art	Heidegger (1935)	All 5 stages (particularly strong in En)	Partial correspondence
5	Art as Experience	Dewey (1934)	All 5 stages	Strong correspondence
6	The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction	Benjamin (1935)	Ba→Nami→En strong. Uzu, Taba conditional	Conditional correspondence
7	The Distribution of the Sensible	Ranciere (2000)	Ba→Nami→En strong. Uzu limited	Conditional correspondence
8	On the Aesthetic Education of Man	Schiller (1795)	All 5 stages	Strong correspondence
9	Aesthetic Theory	Adorno (1970)	Particularly strong in En. Ba correspondence limited	Partial correspondence
10	The Open Work	Eco (1962)	All 5 stages	Strong correspondence

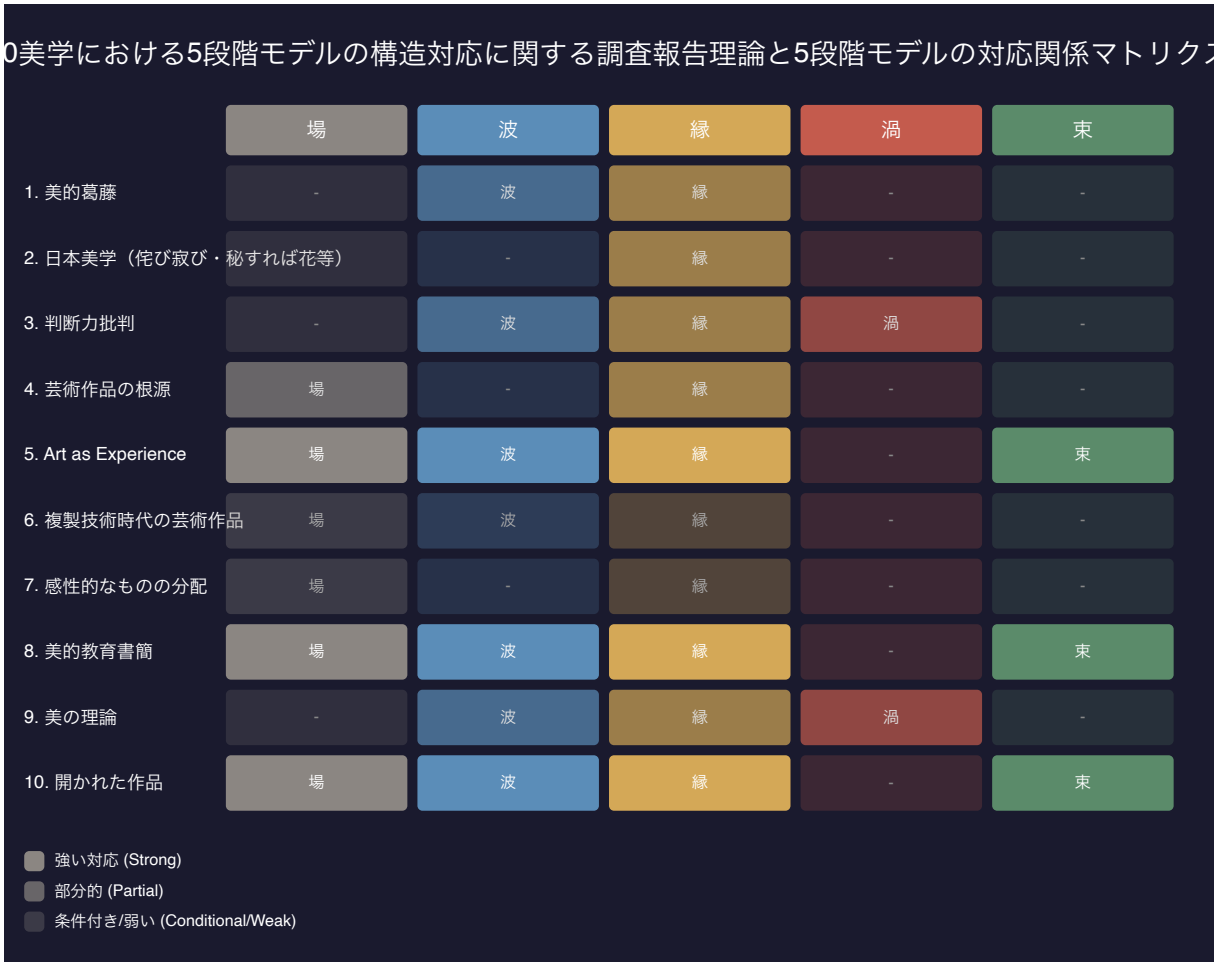

Figure 2: Domain — Theory x 5-Stage Correspondence Matrix

Key Entry 1: Schiller's Theory of Aesthetic Education (Schiller, 1795)

- Schiller argued that there are two fundamental drives within the human interior. One is the "sensuous drive" (Stofftrieb), an orientation toward change in time and toward material. The other is the "formal drive" (Formtrieb), an orientation toward eternity and law. These two drives are inherently opposed, but Schiller positioned a third drive — the "play drive" (Spieltrieb) — as integrating rather than resolving this opposition. The object of the play drive is "living form" (lebende Gestalt), that is, beauty.
- Schiller further describes the aesthetic state as "determinability" (Bestimmbarkeit). This is a state that "determines nothing, either in the real or in the moral sense" but makes every determination possible (Letters 20-21).
- **As fact**: Schiller's theory of aesthetic education is structured around three pillars: the opposition between the sensuous drive and the formal drive, the play drive as their integration, and determinability as the aesthetic state. The famous proposition "man only plays when he is in the full sense of the word a human being, and he is only fully a human being when he plays" (Letter 15) succinctly expresses the claim that the integration of the two drives is the completion of humanity.
- **As reading**: Here we read the structure in which a third drive is established "between" two opposing drives. The level of similarity is structure. We focus on the very placement relationship in which the two terms, the sensuous drive and the formal drive, each function independently but the play drive arises at their point of conjunction. Also, "determinability" is not emptiness but "a state in which the possibility of every determination is open" — a structural description of potentiality.
- **As interpretation**: Determinability corresponds to Ba — a state where nothing is determined but everything is possible. The opposition of the sensuous drive and formal drive corresponds to Nami; the play drive, as the conjunction of these two drives, corresponds to En. The dynamic establishment of "living form," the object of the play drive, corresponds to Uzu; and the recovery of human wholeness through aesthetic education corresponds to Taba. Clear structural correspondence is seen across all five stages. In particular, the play drive, as a third principle established "between" two opposing elements, is one of the most direct philosophical formulations of En among all theories.

Key Entry 2: Dewey's Theory of Aesthetic Experience (Dewey, 1934)

- In *Art as Experience*, Dewey positioned aesthetic experience on the continuum of everyday experience. An "experience" distinguished from experience in general is one in which material "runs its course to fulfillment" and closes as consummation. Parts flow seamlessly into the next, while the whole has unity and its own quality.
- For Dewey, the root of experience lies in "the interaction of the living creature and its environment," involving a phase in which balance is recovered from lack through reaching the environment. Furthermore, the mutual penetration of doing and undergoing is the core of aesthetic experience, and experience has meaning only when the two are combined. Resistance, conflict, and tension are not obstacles but material that generates higher-order equilibrium and harmony.
- **As fact**: Dewey's theory of aesthetic experience describes a rhythm in which, starting from the interaction of the living creature and the environment, the organism moves from lack toward recovery of equilibrium. Doing and undergoing cannot be separated, and their combination gives experience meaning. Consummation is not mere termination but the fulfillment in which experience acquires a unified quality.
- **As reading**: Here we read two structural features: the rhythm of experience — "lack→reaching→recovery of equilibrium" — and the inseparable combination of doing and undergoing. The level of similarity is process. Of particular note is that this rhythm is isomorphically repeated in the artist's production, the audience's reception, and the educational setting. Also, the description of doing and undergoing as "inseparable as a relationship" focuses on the conjunction of two opposing moments.
- **As interpretation**: The undifferentiated starting point of interaction between living creature and environment corresponds to Ba. The phase in which lack becomes conscious and the rhythm rises as fluctuation corresponds to Nami. The conjunction of doing and undergoing corresponds to En — this is a contact point established as an inseparable relationship between two opposing moments. The phase in which higher-order equilibrium spontaneously arises from resistance and tension corresponds to Uzu; and the phase in which experience is fulfilled and completed as "an experience" corresponds to Taba. Structural correspondence is confirmed across all five stages, and

in particular the description of En as the conjunction of doing and undergoing is one of the most philosophically concrete among all theories.

Key Entry 3: Meltzer's Aesthetic Conflict (Meltzer, 1988)

- Meltzer described aesthetic experience from within the Kleinian psychoanalytic framework. "Aesthetic conflict" is the tension between the external beauty of an object and the unknowability of its inner world. When encountering something beautiful, one is torn between the desire to know its interior (curiosity) and fear of knowing (fear). Meltzer argued that the capacity to endure this conflict is the key to mental development.
- In the background is Klein's theory of the paranoid-schizoid position (PS) and depressive position (D). A trigger for tolerating PS-type splitting anxiety is necessary, and this tolerance becomes the condition for moving toward integration (D position).
- **As fact**: Aesthetic conflict is defined as the tension between external beauty and the unknowability of the inner world. The two poles of curiosity and fear form the structure of the conflict, and tolerance of this conflict makes possible integrative mental development. Based on clinical observation, it is described across multiple scales, from the mother-child relationship and the analyst-analysand relationship to the encounter with a work of art.
- **As reading**: Here we read the structure in which two opposing emotions — "wanting to know" and "being afraid" — coexist and the aesthetic experience is at its core a state not resolved to either. The level of similarity is mechanism. We focus on the causal mechanism in which the conflict itself is not the object of resolution but enduring it is the condition of development.
- **As interpretation**: The undifferentiated state prior to the encounter with the object corresponds to Ba; the polarization of curiosity and fear corresponds to Nami. The conflict state in which these two poles coexist without converging to either corresponds to En. The phase in which integration beyond PS-type splitting arises from tolerance of the conflict corresponds to Uzu; and the phase in which integrated object relations are stabilized corresponds to Taba. While other theories describe beauty in epistemological or ontological frameworks, Meltzer describes it from the dimension of emotion, and the distinctive point of making "the unknowability of the other's inner world" the source of conflict is unique.

Cross-Cutting Patterns

- The most prominent feature appearing across aesthetics is the diversity of "En"
- **Conflict type**: Coexistence of curiosity and fear (Meltzer)
- **Suspension type**: Disinterestedness as suspension of interest (Kant)
- **Conjunction type**: The conjunction of the struggle between world and earth (Heidegger)

Unresolved Questions

- Schiller's "determinability" redefines Ba not as "an empty starting point" but as "a state in which the possibility of every determination is open." This is in tension with the usual understanding of Ba in the five-stage model ("nothingness," "drifting"). Whether to understand Ba as maximum potentiality or as undifferentiated blankness has not yet been settled.
- Eco's "open bundle" raises the question of whether something can still be called a Taba if it "doesn't close." The relationship between the definition of Taba (stable pattern, convergence toward order) and "open completion" requires further clarification.
- Whether the description of Benjamin's historical transformation should be included in the scope of the five-stage model is a question about the model's range of application. Depending on whether the five stages describe only individual creative processes or also encompass social and technological transformation, the positioning of the later stages changes.
- Kant, Heidegger, and Dewey are theories also relevant to D13 (Philosophy). The connection and distinction between the aesthetic and philosophical dimensions remain as a cross-domain challenge.

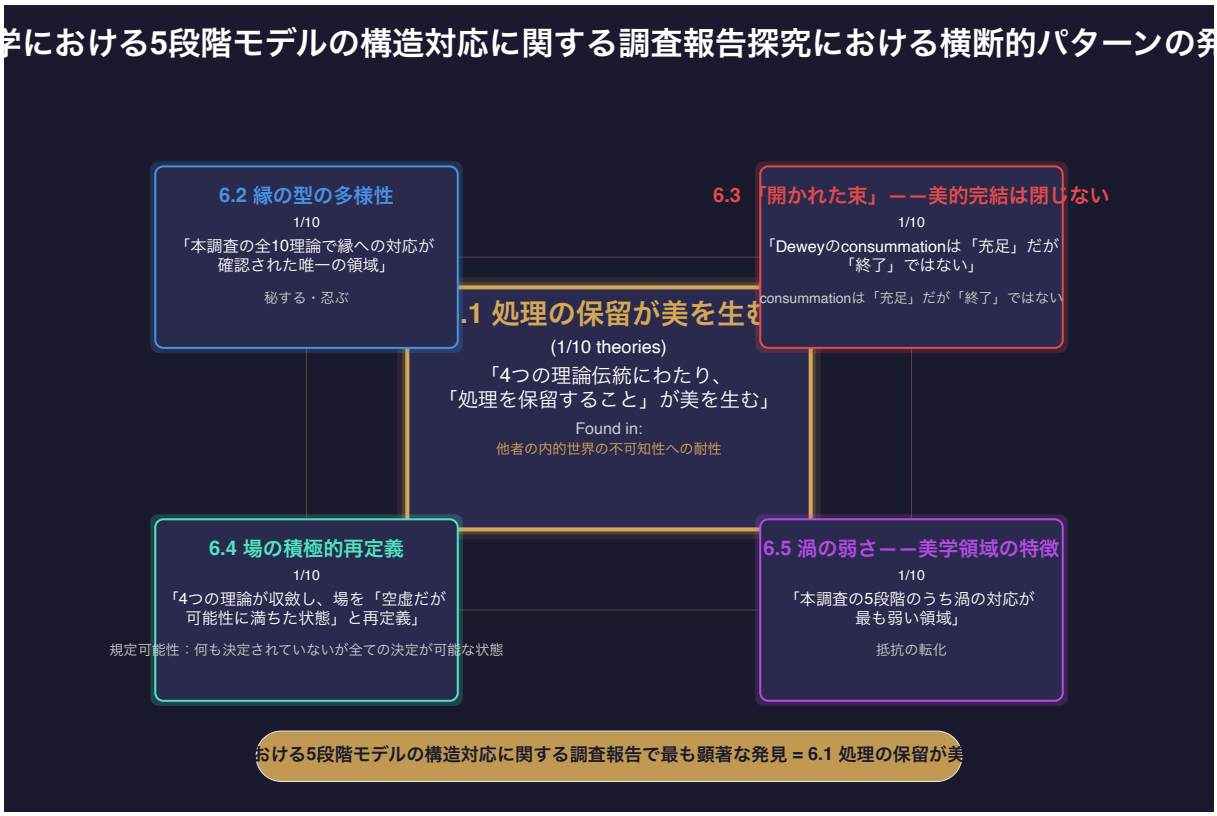

Figure 3: Domain — Cross-Cutting Patterns Diagram

Conclusion

- This survey confirmed that aesthetics is a domain with high overall structural similarity to the five-stage model
- The greatest contribution of aesthetics to understanding the five-stage model is the diversity of “En”
- Another important contribution is the perspective of re-understanding “Taba” not as “closed completion” but as “open completion”